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Wine Country Intelligence

# Central Coast Wine Country Report

Santa Barbara and San Luis Obispo Counties

Q3 2026 Edition | 442 Wineries Evaluated

Prepared by  
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## A Letter from Scott

I have spent a good portion of 2026 visiting tasting rooms, cellars and offices across Santa Barbara and San Luis Obispo counties. I have sat down with nearly 100 winemakers, owners, investors and people who work around this industry, and I'm now fortunate to count several of those wineries as clients.

Everyone I talk to wants to grow. Not everyone wants to grow the same way. One winery's license will not let it pour by the glass, so it lives on bottles and club. Another does most of its business by the glass. Another opens on weekends to pour and talk, and \$750,000 a year is exactly the business its owner wants. These are different businesses with different strategies, and the help on offer, from vendors and sometimes from the organizations that serve the region, too often arrives as one approach for all of them.

That matters more now, because the market is changing under every one of them. Grapes fetch less a ton, growers statewide are pulling vines, and more visitors seem to ask an AI assistant where to taste before they ask anyone else. I do not think that pressure lands evenly. Over the next year this report will look at which business models hold up and which feel the squeeze, starting with the direct-to-visitor side we measure today and widening to wholesale, which we have barely touched.

What follows is what we measured this quarter. Where it is our opinion, we say so.

Scott Hess

# Who AI Puts on the Shortlist

## 45 of 442 wineries account for 47.9% of every time a winery is named by AI

This month AI assistants gave us 2,644 answers on where to taste in each county, and named a winery 23,232 times. The 45 wineries named most often, the top tenth of the 442 we measure, account for 47.9% of those namings; the ten named most often account for 17.6%. 56 of the 442 were never named in an answer to their own county’s questions.

And travelers are asking: MMGY Travel Intelligence’s summer 2026 survey of 4,371 U.S. adults found that 52% of active leisure travelers have used AI to help plan a trip, up 10 points in a year.

**Our read:** the shortlist is increasingly written by AI, and a small group of wineries is on it most of the time.

Wine Country Intelligence clients may appear in these rankings. Clients get no preferential treatment. Every winery is measured the same way, and each one rises or falls on the work it does and on how the AI assistants read what is published about each winery, which changes from month to month as AI assistants mature.

The ten wineries named most often, both counties together:

| #  | Winery                    | Times named | County          |
|----|---------------------------|-------------|-----------------|
| 1  | Sunstone Winery           | 593         | Santa Barbara   |
| 2  | Eberle Winery             | 527         | San Luis Obispo |
| 3  | Tablas Creek Vineyard     | 484         | San Luis Obispo |
| 4  | DAOU Vineyards            | 444         | San Luis Obispo |
| 5  | Roblar Winery             | 388         | Santa Barbara   |
| 6  | JUSTIN Vineyards & Winery | 380         | San Luis Obispo |
| 7  | Gainey Vineyard           | 340         | Santa Barbara   |
| 8  | Fess Parker Winery        | 330         | Santa Barbara   |
| 9  | Melville Winery           | 300         | Santa Barbara   |
| 10 | Halter Ranch Vineyard     | 292         | San Luis Obispo |

Times named: answers that named the winery, out of 1,324 answers about Santa Barbara County and 1,320 about San Luis Obispo County; each county is counted on its own questions.

# What Changed This Quarter

## Since Q2 2026, 40 Central Coast wineries were named by AI less often, and 15 more often

We asked the same 24 questions as last quarter, three times each. Of the 393 wineries we measured both times (we measure 442 this quarter; the difference is wineries that joined our census since then), 40 came up less often and 15 more often. In Santa Barbara County 22 came up less often and 8 more often; in San Luis Obispo County, 18 and 7. About as many wineries were named overall; what changed is which ones.

Most of the drop came from Perplexity and Gemini, the two of the four assistants we asked these questions that search the web for every answer: the times these wineries were named went from 343 to 225, and of those 118 fewer namings, 99 were theirs. Our read is that the change is in what those searches now find, not necessarily at the wineries. A fall here is a change in the answers, measured; it is not a finding about the winery. If yours is named, ask an AI assistant where to taste in your county and see who now appears in your place.

The largest moves each way, as the number of answers that named the winery in each round:

### Largest gains

| Winery                          | County          | Q2 2026  | This quarter   |
|---------------------------------|-----------------|----------|----------------|
| Beckmen Vineyards               | Santa Barbara   | 8 of 48  | 12 to 16 of 48 |
| Claiborne & Churchill Winery    | San Luis Obispo | 9 of 48  | 11 to 14 of 48 |
| Tablas Creek Vineyard           | San Luis Obispo | 19 of 48 | 21 to 23 of 48 |
| Calcareous Vineyard             | San Luis Obispo | 3 of 48  | 5 to 7 of 48   |
| Coquelicot Organic Estate Wines | Santa Barbara   | 0 of 48  | 1 to 3 of 48   |

### Largest declines

| Winery              | County          | Q2 2026  | This quarter   |
|---------------------|-----------------|----------|----------------|
| Brewer-Clifton      | Santa Barbara   | 18 of 48 | 9 to 14 of 48  |
| Chamisal Vineyards  | San Luis Obispo | 22 of 48 | 15 to 18 of 48 |
| Dragonette Cellars  | Santa Barbara   | 12 of 48 | 5 to 8 of 48   |
| Zaca Mesa Winery    | Santa Barbara   | 24 of 48 | 17 to 19 of 48 |
| Fess Parker Winery  | Santa Barbara   | 28 of 48 | 21 to 24 of 48 |
| Foxen Winery        | Santa Barbara   | 13 of 48 | 7 to 9 of 48   |
| Hitching Post Wines | Santa Barbara   | 8 of 48  | 3 to 4 of 48   |
| Kalyra Winery       | Santa Barbara   | 10 of 48 | 5 to 8 of 48   |
| Saucelito Canyon    | San Luis Obispo | 10 of 48 | 5 to 9 of 48   |
| Stolpman Vineyards  | Santa Barbara   | 17 of 48 | 12 to 15 of 48 |

**Why it matters:** Our read: a winery that comes up less often on the shortlist is likely to lose some of the visitors who ask, whether or not anything changed at the winery. The county edition names the largest moves in your county, both ways.

## Five Things Most Wineries Get Wrong

The five gaps we found most often across the 442 wineries in both counties, each counted only where we could check. The line under each is our read of why it costs a winery.

### **1. Not in the search results for “wine tasting” searches: 338 of 442 wineries**

Our read: a visitor who searches for wineries, not for you by name, never sees you.

### **2. No press on the first page of its own name search: 332 of 442 wineries**

Our read: independent coverage is what tells a visitor, and an AI assistant, that someone else vouches for you.

### **3. No tasting notes on the site: 309 of the 438 wineries we could check**

Our read: an assistant asked what a winery pours has nothing of its own words to repeat.

### **4. Not in the Google Maps results for discovery searches: 273 of 442 wineries**

Our read: the visitor searching the map from the car picks from what the map shows.

### **5. No tasting fee on a tasting page: 246 of the 418 wineries we could check**

Our read: an assistant asked what a tasting costs has nothing from your own site to repeat.

Your county edition counts the press, map and tasting-fee gaps across your county and ranks every winery on every category. Monitor tells you which of them you are missing and in which order to fix them; Monitor Plus adds the peers you name, beside you.

## The Market Around You

Every figure here comes from a government report, an industry body or a named news source, and we say which in the sentence. Where we comment, it is our read, and we say why it matters to an owner.

### The good news: our two counties held their value

In a hard year for California grapes, the county crop reports show our two counties held up. The Santa Barbara County crop report values its 2025 wine grapes at \$87.8 million, up 24%; San Luis Obispo County's crop statistics put its crop at \$196.1 million, flat against \$195.0 million in 2024. The same county reports elsewhere fell: Monterey down 25%, Sonoma down 17%, Napa down 6%. USDA's 2025 grape acreage report, in the acreage growers report standing in its county tables, young vines included, shows acreage here slipping more slowly than the state's: 1.9% in San Luis Obispo County and 0.9% in Santa Barbara County, against 3.7% for the state's reported total.

### The hard part: grapes fetch less a ton

USDA's Final Grape Crush report, which records the average price paid per ton, puts District 8, the state's pricing district for San Luis Obispo, Santa Barbara and Ventura counties, at \$1,751.14 a ton for the 2025 crop, down 6.9% from \$1,881.03, a steeper fall than the state's 3.9%. Allied Grape Growers, as reported by the Associated Press, estimates that about half of California's 2026 crop went into harvest without a buyer contract, against 70 to 80% contracted in a typical year. USDA's estimate of all California wine-grape acreage, a wider measure than the reported acreage above, fell 6.9% in 2025, to 540,000 acres. In Paso Robles, the Wine Country Alliance's benchmark of its reporting wineries shows tasting room visitors down 7% in the twelve months through August 2026, the same fall as its California benchmark, and revenue per visitor down 2%, against a 3% rise for California.

### The good news again: the direct sale

Our read, and why it matters to an owner: fruit is a buyer's market this year. A winery that buys grapes has room to secure better fruit or longer terms, and an estate with surplus fruit has more reason to bottle it and sell it direct. The direct sale is the part of the business each winery controls, and it is what the rest of this report measures. Regions are betting on it too: Santa Barbara County's Wine Improvement District reported to the county's supervisors that the "Let's Go!" campaign reached more than 16 million consumers and brought about 66,000 new visitors to its website in two months. The county editions carry each county's own grape market.

Sources for this section: USDA NASS, California Grape Crush Report, Final 2025 (April 30, 2026); USDA NASS, California Grape Acreage Report, 2025 Crop (April 29, 2026); Santa Barbara County Agricultural Commissioner, Crop & Livestock Report 2025 (June 23, 2026); San Luis Obispo County Agricultural Commissioner, 2025 crop statistics, Board of Supervisors agenda for October 6, 2026; Monterey, Napa, Sonoma and San Joaquin County Agricultural Commissioners, 2025 crop reports (July to September 2026); Associated Press, "Farmers toil to sell grapes as wine demand drops" (September 27, 2026); Paso Robles Wine Country Alliance, Community Benchmark: Paso Robles vs California, rolling 12 months through August 2026 (posted October 6, 2026); Santa Barbara County Wine Improvement District, FY 2026-27 Annual Report, Board of Supervisors file 26-00813, Attachment A (September 1, 2026).

## The Leaders

Wine Country Intelligence clients may appear in these rankings. Clients get no preferential treatment. Every winery is measured the same way, and each one rises or falls on the work it does and on how the AI assistants read what is published about each winery, which changes from month to month as AI assistants mature.

One list per category across both counties: the ten highest scores among all 442 wineries we measure, with the county each sits in. Where so many share the top score that a list would rank nothing, we show instead the gaps that keep the rest from it. Wineries on the same score are listed alphabetically, not ranked against each other.

### Overall Digital Readiness (of 100)

What it measures: the seven categories below, added up into one score for how easy a winery is to find, trust, book and buy from online.

JUSTIN Vineyards & Winery leads the two counties at 81.7 of 100.

| #  | Winery                     | Score | County          |
|----|----------------------------|-------|-----------------|
| 1  | JUSTIN Vineyards & Winery  | 81.7  | San Luis Obispo |
| 2  | Roblar Winery              | 75.6  | Santa Barbara   |
| 3  | Sunstone Winery            | 74.4  | Santa Barbara   |
| 4  | Laetitia Vineyard & Winery | 74.1  | San Luis Obispo |
| 5  | Eberle Winery              | 73.1  | San Luis Obispo |
| 6  | Fess Parker Winery         | 73.0  | Santa Barbara   |
| 7  | Carhartt Family Wines      | 70.7  | Santa Barbara   |
| 8  | Wolff Vineyards            | 68.7  | San Luis Obispo |
| 9  | Chamisal Vineyards         | 68.3  | San Luis Obispo |
| 10 | Austin Hope Winery         | 67.9  | San Luis Obispo |

### Third-Party Presence (of 23)

What it measures: do the lists, guides, and press that visitors and AI assistants read name you?

Alma Rosa Winery & Vineyards leads the two counties at 18.5 of 23.

| # | Winery                             | Score | County          |
|---|------------------------------------|-------|-----------------|
| 1 | Alma Rosa Winery & Vineyards       | 18.5  | Santa Barbara   |
| 2 | Laetitia Vineyard & Winery         | 17.2  | San Luis Obispo |
| 3 | DAOU Vineyards                     | 16.0  | San Luis Obispo |
| 4 | Eberle Winery                      | 16.0  | San Luis Obispo |
| 5 | ONX Wines                          | 16.0  | San Luis Obispo |
| 6 | Brewer-Clifton                     | 15.2  | Santa Barbara   |
| 7 | Castoro Cellars Vineyards & Winery | 15.2  | San Luis Obispo |

Scores are shared in this category: three of the seven wineries listed here scored 16.0 and the next score, 14.0, is shared by 10 of the 442 wineries in our two counties, more than the table has room for, so it stops at seven. Wineries sharing a score are listed alphabetically, not ranked against each other, at the top of the table as much as at the cut.

### Review Volume & Reputation (of 25)

What it measures: how many people vouch for you, and are they still doing it?

2 wineries share the lead at 23.7 of 25.

| #  | Winery                                 | Score | County          |
|----|----------------------------------------|-------|-----------------|
| 1  | DAOU Vineyards                         | 23.7  | San Luis Obispo |
| 2  | JUSTIN Vineyards & Winery              | 23.7  | San Luis Obispo |
| 3  | Sculpterra Winery and Sculpture Garden | 22.3  | San Luis Obispo |
| 4  | Tobin James Cellars                    | 22.3  | San Luis Obispo |
| 5  | Sunstone Winery                        | 20.4  | Santa Barbara   |
| 6  | Calcareous Vineyard                    | 19.7  | San Luis Obispo |
| 7  | Niner Wine Estates                     | 19.7  | San Luis Obispo |
| 8  | Laetitia Vineyard & Winery             | 19.2  | San Luis Obispo |
| 9  | Austin Hope Winery                     | 19.1  | San Luis Obispo |
| 10 | Halter Ranch Vineyard                  | 18.7  | San Luis Obispo |

Scores are shared in this category: two of the ten wineries listed here scored 23.7. Wineries sharing a score are listed alphabetically, not ranked against each other, at the top of the table as much as at the cut.

## Search & Map Discovery (of 21)

What it measures: when a visitor searches for wineries rather than for you by name, do you come up, in the results and on the map?

Sunstone Winery leads the two counties at 18.6 of 21.

| # | Winery                         | Score | County          |
|---|--------------------------------|-------|-----------------|
| 1 | Sunstone Winery                | 18.6  | Santa Barbara   |
| 2 | Chamisal Vineyards             | 17.1  | San Luis Obispo |
| 3 | Roblar Winery                  | 17.1  | Santa Barbara   |
| 4 | Buttonwood Farm Winery         | 16.7  | Santa Barbara   |
| 5 | Copia Vineyards and Winery     | 16.1  | San Luis Obispo |
| 6 | JUSTIN Vineyards & Winery      | 16.1  | San Luis Obispo |
| 7 | Fess Parker Winery             | 14.7  | Santa Barbara   |
| 8 | LXV Wine & Pairings Downtown   | 14.7  | San Luis Obispo |
| 9 | Vina Robles Vineyards & Winery | 14.7  | San Luis Obispo |

Scores are shared in this category: two of the nine wineries listed here scored 17.1 and the next score, 14.3, is shared by 3 of the 442 wineries in our two counties, more than the table has room for, so it stops at nine. Wineries sharing a score are listed alphabetically, not ranked against each other, at the top of the table as much as at the cut.

## AI-Ready Booking & Buying (of 14)

What it measures: once someone has picked you, can they book, join, and buy without picking up the phone?

17 of the 442 wineries we measure scored the full 14 points on AI-Ready Booking & Buying, so a list of the first ten would rank nothing. What separates the rest is what they are missing.

The most common gaps, and how many wineries have them:

| What we check                   | Wineries missing it | Of those we could check |
|---------------------------------|---------------------|-------------------------|
| Tasting fee on a tasting page   | 246                 | 418                     |
| Shipping cost shown on the site | 235                 | 438                     |
| Ships direct                    | 148                 | 438                     |
| Visit hours on its own site     | 147                 | 438                     |
| A visit page                    | 136                 | 438                     |
| Online reservations             | 80                  | 438                     |
| A modern checkout               | 28                  | 438                     |

Our read: these are the questions a visitor, and an assistant answering for one, asks just before booking: what does it cost, when are you open, can I book, will you ship. A missing answer is likely to send some visitors to the next winery on the list.

## Profile Accuracy (of 6)

What it measures: does your Google profile state the right facts, and does Apple Maps agree?

92 of the 442 wineries we measure scored the full 6 points on Profile Accuracy, so a list of the first ten would rank nothing. What separates the rest is what they are missing.

The most common gaps, and how many wineries have them:

| What we check                         | Wineries missing it | Of those we could check |
|---------------------------------------|---------------------|-------------------------|
| Google secondary categories           | 227                 | 442                     |
| Google hours complete                 | 74                  | 442                     |
| Google profile claimed                | 42                  | 442                     |
| Apple and Google agree on the address | 21                  | 373                     |
| Apple and Google agree on the phone   | 21                  | 365                     |
| Google attributes set                 | 19                  | 442                     |
| Google profile links the website      | 17                  | 442                     |
| Google primary category is Winery     | 14                  | 427                     |

Our read: the Google profile is what a map, and an assistant reading it, repeats about you. A profile with gaps is a profile that answers some visitors wrongly or not at all.

## Citation Readiness (of 6)

What it measures: when a search engine or AI assistant reads your site, can it get the facts out?

21 of the 442 wineries we measure scored the full 6 points on Citation Readiness, so a list of the first ten would rank nothing. What separates the rest is what they are missing.

The most common gaps, and how many wineries have them:

| What we check                            | Wineries missing it | Of those we could check |
|------------------------------------------|---------------------|-------------------------|
| Tasting notes on the site                | 309                 | 438                     |
| Store prices readable without JavaScript | 242                 | 415                     |
| Club prices readable without JavaScript  | 224                 | 429                     |
| Pages with real substance                | 90                  | 438                     |
| Store page readable without JavaScript   | 78                  | 415                     |
| Club page readable without JavaScript    | 43                  | 429                     |
| Page speed                               | 12                  | 433                     |
| Works on a phone                         | 12                  | 438                     |
| robots.txt allows AI search bots         | 6                   | 440                     |

Our read: an assistant can only repeat what it can read. Prices and pages that appear only after JavaScript runs are likely not what many AI crawlers read, so an assistant asked “how much is the club” may have nothing to say.

Social (of 5)

What it measures: does your Instagram confirm you’re open, active, and worth visiting?

2 wineries share the lead at 5.0 of 5.

| # | Winery                                                     | Score | County          |
|---|------------------------------------------------------------|-------|-----------------|
| 1 | DAOU Vineyards                                             | 5.0   | San Luis Obispo |
| 2 | Riboli Family of San Antonio Winery, Bistro + Tasting Room | 5.0   | San Luis Obispo |

Scores are shared in this category: the next score, 4.6, is shared by 10 of the 442 wineries in our two counties, more than the table has room for, so it stops at two. Wineries sharing a score are listed alphabetically, not ranked against each other, at the top of the table as much as at the cut.

Where Do You Stand?

Three questions this edition cannot answer for you:

- 1. Are you among the 45 wineries that account for 47.9% of every time AI names a winery, or among the 56 never named in an answer to their own county’s questions?
- 2. Which of the gaps in this edition are yours?
- 3. Did your neighbors gain on you this quarter?

Your county edition ranks every winery in your county on all seven categories and names the wineries that moved most. Monitor answers the first two for your own winery every month; Monitor Plus adds the third, for the peers you name.

Where to Go from Here

See where your winery lands

This edition names the leaders. Your county edition ranks every winery in your county; Monitor and Monitor Plus follow your own winery every month. Or book a thirty-minute call and we will walk through where you stand.

Get your county report: [mainstreetiq.com/wineries](https://mainstreetiq.com/wineries) | [scott@mainstreetiq.com](mailto:scott@mainstreetiq.com)

Or book a 30-minute call: [calendly.com/scott\\_mainstreetiq/30min](https://calendly.com/scott_mainstreetiq/30min)

## Ways to subscribe

Annual Monitor and Monitor Plus plans include your county edition.

**Monitor:** your own scorecard every month, and the five Drift Watch alerts the month something moves against you. [mainstreetiq.com/wineries](https://mainstreetiq.com/wineries)

**Monitor Plus:** everything in Monitor, plus four peers you name (more can be added), so you hear when one of them passes you. [mainstreetiq.com/wineries](https://mainstreetiq.com/wineries)

**County edition:** the full quarterly report for Santa Barbara or San Luis Obispo County, with every winery ranked. [mainstreetiq.com/wineries](https://mainstreetiq.com/wineries)

How we measure, in brief. We track every active winery with a public tasting room in the two counties and scored 442 of them this quarter, each measured at one location, on seven categories from public sources only: no surveys, no self-reporting, no private analytics. Separately we ask six AI assistants the trip-planning questions a visitor would ask about each county, three times over the month, and count which wineries they name; that result is never part of the score. The county editions set out the full method.

Independence. Rankings reflect Main Street IQ's own independent measurement of publicly available digital signals. Some wineries ranked here are Wine Country Intelligence clients, as the note at the top of The Leaders says. This report is independent analysis and is not endorsed or sponsored by any company named herein. Company names, trademarks, and brand identities referenced here are the property of their respective owners.

Limits. Scores in this report are based on publicly available data collected via automated tools. Some data points may be incomplete or reflect temporary conditions. This report is provided for informational purposes and does not constitute professional advice. Scores may change as data collection methods improve.

## About Main Street IQ

Main Street IQ gives businesses the kind of rigorous outside analysis that used to be reserved for companies big enough to hire a consulting firm. For wineries, that means an honest read on where you stand against the cohort, which gaps are most likely to be costing you visits and club signups, and a clear order to fix them in. We use AI to do much of the reading and counting, which is how the analysis stays thorough and the cost stays within reach of a working winery.

Scott Hess, who founded the practice, spent twenty years in finance and operations before it. Much of that was in corporate finance at Northern Trust, supporting the leadership of the business, and embedded with luxury and owner-operated brands where the founder still makes every call that matters. The lesson carried across all of it: what decides whether a business grows is usually visible from the outside long before it surfaces in the ledger, and the owner is the last person with time to go looking for it. That is the gap this practice was built to close.

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